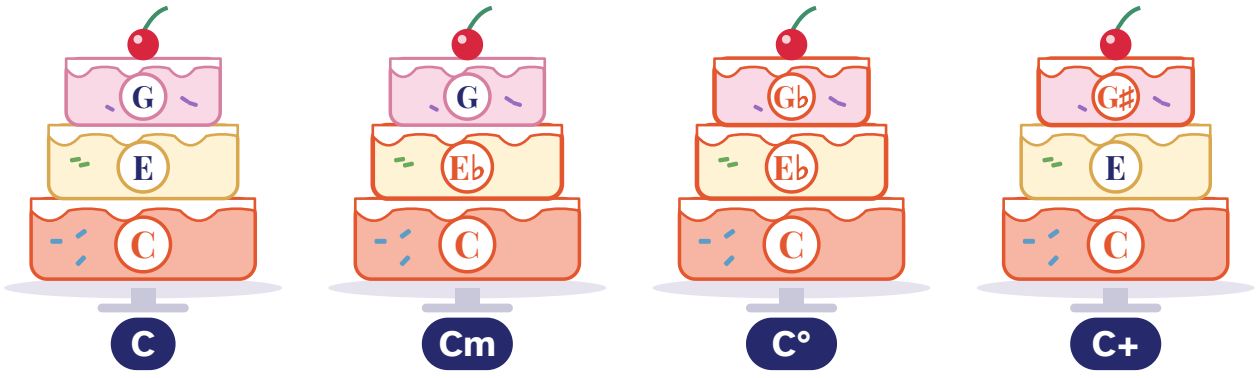
PART V · CHORDS · 2

# Four kinds of triad

Every triad is two 3rds stacked. To tell the kinds apart, count the keys **in between**, black and white, that you do not play: root to 3rd, then 3rd to 5th. Those two numbers name the kind, and its sound.

THE SECRET

**Count the keys between: 3 + 2 is major, 2 + 3 is minor.**

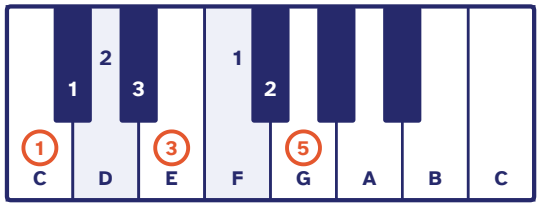



*Count the keys between: 3 + 2 is major, 2 + 3 is minor*

| KIND | KEYS BETWEEN | ON C | CHORD NAME | FIRST MET |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **major** | **3 + 2** | C E G | C | Level ½ |
| **minor** | **2 + 3** | C E♭ G | Cm | Level 2 |
| **diminished** | **2 + 2** | C E♭ G♭ | C° or Cdim | Level 5 |
| **augmented** | **3 + 3** | C E G♯ | C+ or Caug | Level 6 |

Chord names: a letter alone means major (C); m means minor (Cm). You see them above the melody in songbooks and lead sheets: C | Am | F | G. In interval names, 3 keys between is a major 3rd and 2 is a minor 3rd (p. 45).

## Count the keys in between




Play C and E and count the keys you skip, black and white: C♯, D, D♯ is **3**. Then E to G: F, F♯ is **2**. **3 + 2 is major.** Any root works the same way: from D, skip 3 to F♯, then 2 to A: D F♯ A, D major.

PART V · CHORDS · 2 · CONTINUED

## The seven white-key triads, sorted



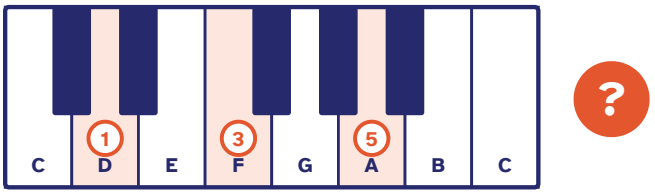

Always the same on the white keys: **three major** (C, F, G), **three minor** (D, E, A), **one diminished** (B), no augmented. Which ones belong to a key is the next chapter (p. 116).

## How they sound

| KIND | SOUNDS | HEARD IN |
|---|---|---|
| major | bright, settled, open | most cheerful tunes, fanfares |
| minor | darker, softer, sadder | lullabies, laments, film tension |
| diminished | tense, unstable, wants to move | suspense, spooky scenes |
| augmented | floating, dreamy, unsettled | dream scenes, a passing colour |

EXAMPLE 1

### Major or minor? D F A




1. **Root to 3rd:** count the keys between D and F, black and white.
2. **3rd to 5th:** count the keys between F and A.
3. **3 + 2 or 2 + 3?**

D to F has 2 between, F to A has 3: **2 + 3**, so D F A is **D minor** (Dm).

GAME

### Which kind?

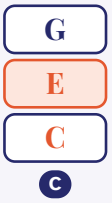
| | | |
|---|---|---|
| G♭ | A | B♯ |
| E♭ | F♯ | G♯ |
| C | D | E |
| 1 | 2 | 3 |

Count the keys between: 3 + 2 major, 2 + 3 minor, 2 + 2 diminished, 3 + 3 augmented.

Answer: 1 diminished · 2 major · 3 augmented.

PART V · CHORDS · 2 · CONTINUED

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

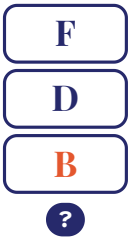



**C E G, then C E♭ G, then C E♭ G♭.**

Bright, dark, tense. Only the middle layer moves first, then the top one. Listen for the change each time.

EXAMPLE 2

**What kind is the triad on B?**




1. **Skip a letter:** B, D, F.
2. **Count the keys between** B and D, then D and F.
3. **Which kind has those two numbers?**

2 + 2: B D F is **B diminished** (B°), the only diminished triad on the white keys.

YOU KNOW THIS

**Beethoven, Moonlight Sonata (first movement)**




The famous slow triplets are the notes of a **C♯ minor triad**: C♯, E and G♯, rocking gently. Minor is why it sounds so dark and sad.

THINK OF IT Two gaps in the cake: a wide one (3 keys between) and a narrow one (2). Major: wide, then narrow, 3 + 2. Minor: narrow, then wide, 2 + 3. Diminished: two narrow, 2 + 2. Augmented: two wide, 3 + 3.

TRAP

- × Counting the keys you play: count only the keys in between, black and white.
- × Forgetting that in diminished and augmented triads the 5th changes too.
- × Spelling with the wrong letter: a triad skips one letter, so C minor is C E♭ G, never C D♯ G.

SEE ALSO
Chords and triads p. 110 · Major, minor and perfect p. 45

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 3–4 · Online: Library › Chords